half of their collection, keeping the rest for their own costs, such as for keeping armies. ‘For this reason, the common people suffer much hardship, [because] those who hold the land [are] so tyrannical.’



Figure 8. Talarigatta Gate, one of the entrances to the city

Further, writes Nuniz, all goods that enter the city are taxed. Most of the produce and merchandise sold in the city comes from outside, and ‘every day there enter by these gates 2,000 oxen’ and all but a few exempted ox-carts pay tax. To get an audience with the king, a merchant has to offer a gift ‘of the best that he has brought’, say, textiles or a horse. Nuniz knew because he was a horse trader himself. ‘And this not only to the king,’ adds Nuniz. ‘You must perforce pay bribes to all the several officers with whom you have to deal. They will do nothing without some profit to themselves.’ Some cultural habits have deep roots, it seems.

The people of Vijayanagar do not kill or eat oxen and cows, for they worship them. But ‘they eat mutton, pork, venison, partridges, hares, doves,